FIGHTERS OF THE INDIAN WARS

The westward expansion of the United States in the second half of the 19th century brought white settlers into conflict with Native American peoples, who defended their territories by carrying out hit-and-run raids and ambushing travellers. The US army sought to drive the Indians off their lands and hunted down bands that refused to submit. These campaigns rarely came to pitched battle. US forces typically found themselves tracking an elusive enemy across thousands of kilometres of wilderness. Foot soldiers proved of little use and by 1877 the US army contained almost 11,000 cavalrymen, compared with only 10,000 infantry. The Native Americans fought with no real hope of victory but great skill and courage. By 1890 their resistance had been pitilessly crushed.

US CAVALRY

The cavalry force with which the United States fought the Sioux, Apache, Nez Percé, and other Native American mounted warriors was largely created at the end of the American Civil War. Its higher ranks were staffed from the large surplus of Union officers available when the Civil War armies disbanded. The enlisted men it attracted were a rag-bag of footloose adventurers, those in trouble with the law, fresh immigrants from Europe who spoke little English, and even a fair number of former Confederate officers. Two regiments of white-officered African-American cavalry, nicknamed "buffalo soldiers" by the Kiowa people, performed with great credit.

Cavalry troopers faced a hard life, garrisoning remote forts, escorting travellers through disputed territory, and mounting campaigns against Indian warbands. The US cavalry were generally slower-moving than their highly mobile enemies. In the early years a trooper typically carried 22kg (50lb) of equipment, including a 2kg (5lb) sword, and 7kg (15lb) of grain for his horse. Gradually they learned to imitate Indian tactics. In 1876 troopers pursuing Crazy Horse were ordered to carry only a tin cup, a carbine and ammunition, and four days' rations, while their horses fed on grass, not grain. Extensive use was made of Indian scouts, whose skill at tracking and speed of movement were invaluable. The counterinsurgency war conducted by the cavalry was often vicious and included massacres of women and children, but as fighting men they showed skill and tenacity in taking on a skilful enemy in difficult terrain.



Henry Model 1860
The Henry rifle was one of the first practical repeating rifles, which saw some army use in the 1860s. Other cavalry firearms included the Colt pistol and the Spencer rifle and carbine.

Little Big Horn
A contingent of the US 7th Cavalry was surrounded and massacred by Sioux and Cheyenne warriors at Little Big Horn in 1876, the worst cavalry defeat of the Indian wars.